EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

The Four Steps of Teshuvah: Where They Come From

Given Monday 17 March 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 5:4-5

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 5 (Merits and Demerits), the end of Chapter 4 (categories 6 to 9) and Chapter 5 (the penitent)

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 3 February 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Merits, Demerits and Ten Categories

The fifth essay is on *zechuyot vechovot*, merits and demerits, mitzvot and aveirot. The first four chapters established:

- A person's deeds divide into merits and demerits, and every action leaves an impression on one's character, positive or negative.
- HaKadosh Baruch Hu records everything, and everything has its consequence, in this world, the next, or both.
- Saadia's theodicy: why the righteous sometimes suffer, and (last week) six reasons why the wicked seem to prosper and live long.
- **Ten categories of people.** "Saadia always likes numbers." Five have been seen:

#	Category	Definition
1	**Tzaddik**	More merits than demerits; judged by the majority
2	**Rasha**	More demerits than merits
3	**Oved**	Singles out one mitzvah to which he is committed come what may. "We should all really try to do that in our lives." The Rambam and Rabbi Yosef Albo in the Ikkarim agree that one such mitzvah earns a portion in the world to come
4	**Mamre**	Singles out one mitzvah he refuses, ideologically, ever to perform: a *mumar ledavar echad*
5	**Shalem**	Keeps **all** the mitzvot. A level above the tzaddik. Saadia holds it is possible, and reinterprets the verses that seem to say otherwise

Tonight: categories six to nine, which close Chapter 4, and the tenth, the penitent, to which Saadia devotes Chapter 5.

Chapter 4: Categories 6 to 9, in Ascending Severity

"Pay attention to six, seven, eight and nine. They are in ascending order in terms of severity."

6. The Mekatzer: the negligent

A person who keeps everything, but is **lax with positive commandments**. Not ideologically or wilfully; he is just not particularly interested in performing them. They are the kinds of mitzvot from which women are exempt, and which a man may have no interest in doing.

7. The Choteh: the offender

A person who **violates negative commandments, but not the severe ones**. How do we know what is severe? By the punishment. These are prohibitions without death or *karet*: eating non-kosher food, wearing *shaatnez*, superstitious practices, deceit and the like. More severe than neglecting positive commandments, but without the gravest consequences.

8. The Mezid: the rebellious offender

A person who **intentionally violates the severe negative commandments**, those carrying the death penalty or *karet*: the forbidden relationships, desecrating Shabbat, eating on Yom Kippur, eating chametz on Pesach.

Note that this is a different kind of label from tzaddik and rasha. A person may have more merits than demerits and still carry the label *mezid*, because he has violated one of the Torah's severe prohibitions.

9. The Kofer: the denier

A person who **leaves the root**, who denies God. There are three ways:

	The denier who...	
9a	**serves something else**: idols, the sun, the moon, a human being	"Even if you believe in God, but you've served other forms, you are now a kofer"
9b	**serves nothing at all**	He is simply not interested. "This is probably one of the most common ones nowadays"
9c	**has significant doubts** about his faith	People call him a believer, part of the community; he may even pray. "But deep down he's not a believer... He puts on a show." As the verse says, **ויפתוהו בפיהם**, they beguiled Him with their mouths, but the heart was not there

Anyone in this ninth category, Saadia says, **is called one who desecrates the name of Heaven**.

Teshuvah fully atones for all nine categories, except for **four sins** which, even with complete teshuvah, still require some consequence in this world. Saadia says he will explain them in Chapter 6.

Saadia and the Gemara in Yoma: the source of the Rambam's four levels

"This is very interesting, because the Rambam almost mimics this later on, in Hilchot Teshuvah chapter 1," learnt on Tuesday nights some time ago.

The Gemara in **Yoma** already distinguishes severe prohibitions, those carrying death or *karet*, from lesser ones. Saadia further divides the lesser offences into neglect of positive commandments and violation of negative ones. "The Gemara doesn't do that. Saadia is doing it of his own accord, but the principle is there."

And when he adds, of the *kofer*, that he is **מחלל שם שמים**, "I'm certain he's referring here to the Gemara in Yoma, which the Rambam quotes."

Saadia	The Rambam, Hilchot Teshuvah ch. 1	What atones
6. Mekatzer (positive commandments)	Neglect of a positive commandment	**Teshuvah alone**, immediately. "I haven't been putting on tefillin... I decide I'm going to start. That's it." No need for Yom Kippur
7. Choteh (lesser negative commandments)	Negative commandments without death or *karet*	**Teshuvah and Yom Kippur**: "what Yom Kippur is most effective for"
8. Mezid (death or *karet*)	Prohibitions carrying *karet* or death	**Teshuvah, Yom Kippur and suffering** in this world
9. Kofer	**Chillul Hashem**	Teshuvah, Yom Kippur, suffering, **and death**: full atonement comes only with death

The Rambam does not define *chillul Hashem* in Hilchot Teshuvah, and defines it differently elsewhere. **Saadia defines it as the denier**, in any of his three forms. That is why he "threw in this sentence" about desecrating the name of Heaven.

Chapter 5: The Tenth Category, the Penitent

העשירי הוא השב, the tenth is the penitent, who performs the conditions of teshuvah.

"As I've said many times as we've been learning this book, the reason I love this book, and why it's such an important one, is because so many things which we are accustomed to believing, this is just how things have always been, this is what Judaism has always said, actually originate in this book."

Every year we hear about the process of teshuvah and its parts. But **nowhere in the Talmud** is there a set list of the ingredients of teshuvah. The Gemara speaks of teshuvah generally and mentions elements here and there. **Saadia is the very first to put the ingredients together**, "and literally everyone copied him after this": Rabbeinu Bachya in **Chovot HaLevavot**, the **Rambam**, Rabbeinu Yonah in **Shaarei Teshuvah**, and the **Meiri** in his *Chibbur HaTeshuvah*. "Each of these individual ingredients is scattered across the Tanach... but putting it together and explaining that this is the process of teshuvah, Saadia was the very first one to do this."

The four ingredients

#	Ingredient	Time
1	**עזיבת החטא**: leaving the sin, stopping what you are doing	The present
2	**חרטה**: regret and remorse	The past
3	**בקשת כפרה**: a request for atonement, what we call *vidui*, confession	
4	**קבלה**: firm resolve not to repeat the sin	The future

All four are needed.

All four in one passage: Hoshea 14

As usual, Saadia prefers to go straight to Scripture rather than quote the Chachamim. He finds all four in the opening verses of the **Haftarah of Shabbat Shuvah**, "and for Saadia this is the perfect haftarah":

> **שובה ישראל עד ה' אלהיך כי כשלת בעונך. קחו עמכם דברים ושובו אל ה', אמרו אליו כל תשא עון וקח טוב ונשלמה פרים שפתינו. אשור לא יושיענו, על סוס לא נרכב, ולא נאמר עוד אלהינו למעשה ידינו.**
>
> **שובה ישראל**, "return, Israel": stop now what you are doing. Leaving the sin in the present.
>
> **כי כשלת בעונך**, "for you have stumbled in your iniquity": you recognise it as a **stumbling**, a failure, an obstacle in the path of your character. That is regret.
>
> **קחו עמכם דברים**, "take words with you": confession, the request for atonement.
>
> **ולא נאמר עוד אלהינו למעשה ידינו**, "we will no longer call the work of our hands our god": the resolve not to lapse back into sin.

Two digressions on difficult words

Because he is explaining the verses, Saadia "takes the liberty" of explaining two puzzling phrases.

> **כל תשא עון וקח טוב.** All the Rishonim struggle with this. The **Ibn Ezra** gives perhaps the easiest reading by swapping the words: "forgive all sin, and accept our good." Saadia will not swap them. Instead he explains **כל** not as "all" but as **"corresponding to," "in accordance with"**: in return for Your bearing our iniquity, accept from us the prayer declaring that You are good. He shows the usage from:

- **Daniel 2:8**, in Aramaic: **כל קבל די חזיתון**, "because you see that the matter has escaped me," you are playing for time. Everyone agrees *kol kevel* there does not mean "all."
- **Kohelet 5:15**, in Hebrew: **כל עמת שבא כן ילך**, "just as he came, so shall he go."

> **כל הבאיש על עם לא יועילו למו** is the same usage.

"If you didn't get the exact word here, it's fine, don't worry about it. But I just found it really interesting. For me it was actually something new."

> **ונשלמה פרים שפתינו**, literally "and we will pay bulls, our lips." Either add a letter, **כפרים**, "*like* bulls," or supply a few missing words: may what we offer with our lips, the confession and the request for atonement, be accepted **as if we had offered sacrifices**. Same meaning either way.

Why Ashur, the horse and idols?

Why does the prophet mention these three in particular? Because in Hoshea's time **these were the sins the people were embroiled in**, as the start of the book says, **כי המה עלו אשור פרא בודד לו**, they went up to Ashur, a wild ass alone. "If the most prevalent sins were murder and adultery, he would have said that."

Different Verses, the Same Four Ingredients

After Saadia, all the Rishonim followed his four ingredients. So did **Rabbeinu Nissim** (not the Ran, the commentator on the Talmud) in the long *vidui* recited on Yom Kippur in almost every community, some in Shacharit, some at Minchah, some at night, "a very long and really emotional confession," built on the same four elements.

They differ only on which verse proves which point:

Ingredient	Saadia	Others
Leaving the sin	**שובה ישראל**	The Rambam and Rabbeinu Bachya: **יעזב רשע דרכו**, "let the wicked forsake his way," which is more explicit
Regret	**כי כשלת בעונך**	Rabbeinu Bachya: **מי יודע ישוב ונחם** (Yoel). The Rambam: **כי אחרי שובי נחמתי** (Yirmiyahu)
Confession	**קחו עמכם דברים**	The Rambam: **ומודה ועוזב ירחם**, "he who confesses and forsakes will find mercy," a verse said in Selichot
Resolve	**ולא נאמר עוד אלהינו למעשה ידינו**	**All the Rishonim** use Saadia's verse

The Rambam's "little spin"

The Rambam, Hilchot Teshuvah 2:2, defines teshuvah: the sinner leaves his sin, removes it from his thoughts and resolves never to do it again, as it says, **יעזב רשע דרכו**; he regrets the past, as it says, **כי אחרי שובי נחמתי**; **ויעיד עליו יודע תעלומות**, and the One who knows all secrets will testify that he will never return to this sin, as it says, **ולא נאמר עוד אלהינו למעשה ידינו**.

"I just realised now": the Rambam uses the verse **in two ways**. "Our god" is the idol, the work of our hands; but **Eloheinu** is also the true God, who will testify that we will no longer make the work of our hands our gods.

The Rambam's major change: three, then confession

"Secondly, the major, major point." For Saadia, teshuvah is **one big thing**: all four ingredients lumped together. The Rambam uses the same four, but differently. Teshuvah itself is **three**: *azivah*, *charatah* and *kabbalah*, the present, the past and the future. Only after these does the fourth, **vidui**, come in. "You can't really do vidui before you do the other three parts." (The class went into this in great detail when it learnt Hilchot Teshuvah.)

The Missing Ingredient, and Why We Have Selichot

Saadia then makes an observation about his own community:

The majority of our nation do teshuvah with every ingredient bar one. They confess a great deal, they regret a great deal, they stop. But I sense that they find the fourth difficult. When they come on Yom Kippur and pray and fast, they stop, they regret and they ask for atonement, but they are not actually committed to not doing it again.

How can people be inspired to firm resolve? Saadia's answer is "fascinating": **compose poems** about the **futility of this world**, about how a person should separate himself from its vanities; poems about human frailty, how we will die and decompose in the grave, and all the suffering we will go through, until a person becomes repulsed by this world and by sin, and will not want to go back to it.

That, Saadia says, is why the earlier rabbis wrote all kinds of poems for these days. "This is where the concept of poems and Selichot comes from."

The Rabbi drew out the history:

- There is **no concept of Selichot in the Talmud**. They were composed after the Talmud, which is why reciting them is a *minhag*. There is no halachah to recite Selichot at any time, even on Erev Yom Kippur. ("I know we Sephardim do Selichot from forty days before, from Elul, but this is all later customs.")
- The first Selichah whose author we know for certain is by **Rabbi Shlomo HaBavli**, in the tenth century. There are very likely earlier ones whose authors and dates we do not know.
- And already in Saadia we see the idea of poems for Yom Kippur.

"This is why I say every year: the piyutim and the Selichot nowadays, unless you are actually following with the English translation of what these things mean, they're really pointless. Because there's no intrinsic value in saying the piyutim and the Selichot, aside from what Saadia is telling us, which is to arouse us to teshuvah and to resolve not to re-offend."

Singing them "with your loudest voice" without knowing what they mean misses their purpose, and in truth they are poems that are sometimes hard to understand, "and very often only the poet himself understood what he was writing." The main part of Selichot is the Thirteen Attributes and the confessions; the piyutim are there to arouse us.

Three Further Aids

Saadia adds three things that help teshuvah. "They're not the main ingredients, but they are like the sauce. They're like the gravy, if you like."

1. **An increase in prayer.**
2. **An increase in justice** (*tzedek*).
3. **Teaching others** to become better: **אלמדה פשעים דרכיך וחטאים אליך ישובו**, "I will teach transgressors Your ways, and sinners will return to You."

On the second, some texts read **tzedakah**, charity, which would fit the Rambam and other sources. But Saadia's proof is **בחסד ואמת יכפר עון**, "through kindness and truth iniquity is atoned." He reads *chesed* as prayer, asking for God's mercy; and if the other word meant charity, "I'm not sure why charity is called truth." So the Rabbi thinks it is *tzedek*: a commitment to justice and straightness, though it could include charity.

The **Rambam** lists prayer and charity, not teaching others, and adds **changing one's name** and **exile**. As the class explained when learning Hilchot Teshuvah, these mean **creating a new identity**: "change your name, change who you are, change your perceptions, change your values. Exile from your place, start again fresh."

Relapse Does Not Undo Teshuvah

The last point of the chapter. "These are things we hear year in, year out, but Saadia is the first one, to my knowledge, to formulate this":

If a person does sincere teshuvah and it is accepted, and afterwards he relapses, **his previous teshuvah is not affected**. All his earlier sins remain forgiven. Only the new sins count, from a clean slate. Even if this happens many times.

This is not the person the Mishnah describes, who says "I will sin and repent, I will sin and repent"; that does not work. It is the person who genuinely regrets, resolves and confesses, and a month later falls back. "This happens. We're human beings, we're frail."

The dry cleaner

People ask on Yom Kippur: is it worth it, if I end up the same? First, that should not be the case every year; if it is, something is wrong. But leaving that aside, the Rabbi's analogy: you take your suit or dress to the dry cleaner even though you know it will get dirty again at the next wedding. A little dirt is much easier to clean than dirt that has built up. Accumulated sin becomes "much more lodged into your character," and needs a far greater effort to change.

"For three transgressions... but for four"

Do not misread this to mean that after repenting three .(Amos) **על שלשה פשעי... ועל ארבעה לא אשיבנו** times, a fourth lapse cannot be repented. Saadia: it refers only to **punishment**. If a person sins and repents after the first, second and third summons, Hashem does not bring what was decreed. On the fourth, teshuvah still works and wipes the slate, but **if a decree has already been set, the punishment must still come**. "Quite a novel point." The Rambam, in Hilchot Teshuvah chapter 3, interprets the verse differently, "more .Talmudically, to be honest," as the class discussed at the time

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Summary

1. **Categories 6 to 9**, in rising severity: the **mekatzer** (lax in positive commandments), the **choteh** (lesser negative commandments), the **mezid** (death or *karet*), and the **kofer**, who serves another, serves nothing, or harbours serious doubt behind a show of belief.
2. These map onto the **Gemara in Yoma** and the **Rambam's four levels of atonement**; Saadia identifies *chillul Hashem* with the *kofer*.
3. **Saadia is the first to define the ingredients of teshuvah**: leaving the sin, regret, confession and resolve, all found in **Hoshea 14**. Every later Rishon follows him; all quote his verse for resolve.
4. Along the way: **כל** as "corresponding to," and **פרים שפתינו** as "*like* bulls."
5. **The Rambam** puts the three inner steps first and confession after; Saadia treats teshuvah as one whole.
6. **Resolve is the weak link**, and **Selichot and piyutim** exist to strengthen it, which is why they must be understood.
7. **Three aids:** prayer, justice (or charity) and teaching others. The Rambam adds a new name and exile: a new identity.
8. **Relapse does not undo earlier teshuvah**; the "fourth transgression" concerns a decree already set.

Coming Up

Chapter 6: more on prayer and teshuvah, and the four sins that teshuvah alone does not fully atone. Chapter 7: an eleventh category, the **beinoni**, whose merits and demerits are equal. Chapter 8: some thoughts "about thoughts." Next week, be'ezrat Hashem, Chapters 6 and 7, perhaps 8 as well.

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